



The Question is: Digital or Conventional?

Ever since the arrival of the multi-megapixel cameras, imaging technologists predicted the death of conventional cameras. But even though we now have digital cameras touching the 6 megapixel mark, they are still a far cry from the quality that conventional photography exhibits. However, the two sides of the digital/conventional coin have their own shortcomings and advantages.

DIGITAL CAMERAS

- ✓ There are less moving parts and the build is sturdier
- ✓ No cost of paying for film over time
- ✓ The ability to preview images lets you retake photographs until you're satisfied
- ✓ Smaller size of CCD allows for much smaller cameras that are highly portable
- ✓ Images are not affected by X-ray machines while on vacation
- ✓ Effortless transfer to computer for further digital processes and applications
- ✗ Far more expensive than conventional cameras
- ✗ Use up batteries very quickly
- ✗ LCD screens are hard to see in bright sun light and dark environments
- ✗ Maintaining colour accuracy between the cameras and printer requires one to learn the process of colour matching

CONVENTIONAL CAMERAS

- ✓ Far superior image quality
- ✓ Up to five times more affordable than their digital counterparts
- ✓ Easy to use and simple learning curve
- ✓ Lower cost of printing
- ✓ Longer lifespan for the prints as compared to printouts of digital images
- ✗ Film processing costs add up over time
- ✗ No way of previewing a photo; you have to pay for unsatisfactory prints
- ✗ Prints can be adversely affected by dust and scratches
- ✗ Negatives and slides are difficult to organise, store and retrieve and have the disadvantage of fading over time

capable of keeping its shutter open for up to 16 seconds. The fastest shutter speed it supported was 1/800th of a second—almost three times slower than the Casio QV-2800UX, which had the fastest shutter speed of 1/2000th of a second.

Metering: Very often, even with conventional cameras, the images appear slightly different from the original scene—the reds may appear too highlighted, or the overall tone of the image might be slightly dull or washed out. This happens when the exposure, shutter speed and aperture of the camera are incorrectly set for that particular scene. Most newer cameras incorporate advanced systems that are capable of setting these parameters perfectly in accordance with the focusing system depending upon the type of scene, be it a portrait, a landscape, or a close-up. This is known as metering. It lets the camera decide which areas of the photo to focus on. There are three modes of metering: spot metering, center-weighted metering, and matrix metering (see 'Jargon Buster').

In the sub-2.0 megapixel cameras, there was no way one could invoke these modes manually. The camera that implemented metering very well, as proved by the level of detail in the resultant image, was the Kodak EasyShare DX3215. A worthy second was the Fuji FinePix A101, which implemented a 64-zone metering system, producing very good imaging results.

The situation was markedly different in the 2+ megapixel category. The Nikon CoolPix 775 implemented metering very effectively. It used a 256-zone metering system, producing very sharp images. All

night time photography and include motion blur in your photographs. Most digital cameras offered shutter speeds ranging from half a second to 1/1000 second. Some high-end cameras even allow users to manually select from a range of shutter speed settings.

In the sub-2.0 megapixel category, the Casio GV-10 offered the best range of

shutter speeds, from 1 second to 1/1500th of a second. This would make the camera a good choice for shooting outdoor sporting events—you would see no blur in the photos. The D-Link DSC-350, the Benq DC300 and the Logitech ClickSmart 510 had a fixed shutter speed with no range to select from.

In the 2+ megapixel category, the Olympus Camedia 2100 Ultra Zoom was



Fuji FinePix A101

One of the smallest 1.3 megapixel cameras available, the Fuji FinePix A101 sports everything from a 1.6-inch TFT to USB connectivity and even the capability to record small video clips. The camera is very small and fits snugly in your pocket. With a maximum resolution

of 1280x1024, it is ideal for sharing images on the Web. It features a 2x digital zoom and the image quality is surprisingly good for a fixed focus camera. This camera offers three modes of operation—image capture, video recording and image playback. Also impressive is the menu navigation system that can be

controlled by the four-directional switch to change the resolution, flash modes and white balance. One very interesting feature here is the ability to zoom into the picture in the playback mode and even pan around while viewing it. Memory is in the form of a 16 MB Smart Media card.

The camera has everything you would need for basic photography and comes at a good price. Though not too heavy on features, it provides good performance that would rival even some of the more expensive ones.

Price: Rs 16,929

Fuji FinePix A101	
Features	▶▶▶▶▶
Ergonomics	▶▶▶▶▶
Performance	▶▶▶▶▶
Warranty & support	▶▶▶▶▶
Value for money	▶▶▶▶▶
OVERALL	▶▶▶▶▶

- + Compact form factor, options to control flash and white balance
- Rather limited maximum resolution of 1280x1024